



International Center for
Transdisciplinary Studies

Regulations of the International Center for Transdisciplinary Studies

CENTER REGULATIONS · ICTS

ASCES-UNITA · Istituto Universitario Sophia (IUS) · Sophia ALC
Loppiano (FI), Italia

These Regulations govern the functioning, internal organization, and rules of conduct of the members of the International Center for Transdisciplinary Studies (ICTS) in relation to its main objectives.

PART I – ESTABLISHMENT AND STRUCTURE OF THE CENTER

Article 1 — Establishment and Identity of the ICTS

The International Center for Transdisciplinary Studies (hereinafter: ICTS) is established through the collaboration of two Universities and Higher Education Institutions already linked by framework agreements for international cooperation. The following institutions are members of the ICTS: the Centro Universitário Tabosa de Almeida ASCES-UNITA and the Istituto Universitario Sophia (IUS), also through the Sophia Latin America and Caribbean Academic Training and Extension Center (Sophia ALC), which represents its first expression on the American continent. The ICTS is established with the aim of promoting transdisciplinary and international research, overcoming traditional disciplinary boundaries and fostering cooperation among academic and institutional entities.

Article 2 — Administrative Headquarters and Operational Sites

The administrative headquarters of the ICTS, responsible for administrative and financial management, is established at the Istituto Universitario Sophia (Via San Vito 28, Loppiano, 50064 Figline e Incisa Valdarno (FI), Italy). The ICTS may establish decentralized offices according to its operational, research, and collaborative needs. For the performance of its activities, the ICTS may make use of the facilities and resources made available by the partner Universities and Institutions.

PART II – STRUCTURE AND GOVERNING BODIES OF THE CENTER

The internal structure of the ICTS consists of several bodies which, together, ensure the proper functioning, strategic management, and implementation of the Center's activities. In particular, the composition of the Center includes:

- ◆ Research Units, which constitute the permanent branches of the Center. They are composed of at least two members and are responsible for territorial presence and operational activities.
- ◆ Governing Bodies, consisting of the Director, the Center Council, the Scientific Committee, and the Ethics Committee, each with specific roles and responsibilities aimed at ensuring research quality, operational support, and compliance with ethical principles.

The individual components listed above are described in detail below.

Article 3 — Research Units

Research Units are the permanent institutional structures that ensure the presence and activity of the Center within its affiliated locations.

- ◆ a) Each Unit shall consist of at least two members and shall operate within the affiliated institutions.
- ◆ b) Each Unit shall appoint a Coordinator, who shall become an ex officio member of the Center Council.
- ◆ c) The Coordinator shall serve a four-year term and may be re-elected only once, unless all other members have already held the position or have declined to assume it.
- ◆ d) Research Units shall communicate the location of their operational headquarters within three months of the establishment of the Research Unit or the signing of the relevant agreement.

Article 4 — The Director of the Center

The Director is the official representative of the ICTS and oversees its overall activities. The Director shall be elected by the Council by simple majority and must be a professor of one of the partner Universities.

The Director's principal responsibilities are:

- ◆ a) convening and chairing the Center Council;
- ◆ b) convening and chairing the Scientific Committee and promoting its activities;
- ◆ c) submitting to the Center Council all matters within the Director's competence for examination and approval;
- ◆ d) presenting an annual report on the activities carried out by the Center to the Council for its consideration.

In the event of absence or inability to perform their duties, the Director may temporarily delegate their functions to another member of the Center Council. Such delegation may not exceed six months in duration.

Article 5 — The Center Council

The Council is the decision-making and operational body of the ICTS, responsible for strategic direction and administrative management. During the initial implementation phase of the Center, the Council shall be constituted in a restricted form in accordance with the provisions of the founding Framework Agreement. At the end of the first four-year term, the Council shall be renewed according to the ordinary composition provided for in these Regulations, with the inclusion of the Coordinators of the Research Units.

A) The Council shall consist of:

- ◆ the Coordinators of the Research Units;
- ◆ one additional representative designated by the Coordinator of the Unit located at the administrative headquarters;

- ◆ Coordinators of affiliated Units established by agreement (Article 9), who may be invited to attend meetings as observers without voting rights.

B) Term of Office and Functioning:

- ◆ The Council shall remain in office for four years.
- ◆ It shall be convened by the Director at least once a year and may conduct its meetings remotely.
- ◆ The Secretary shall prepare the minutes of each meeting within ten days of its occurrence. The minutes shall be circulated to the members of the Council for approval. Approved minutes shall be archived at the administrative headquarters and distributed to Council members.
- ◆ Extracts of resolutions shall be communicated to the persons directly concerned in order to ensure transparency and implementation of the decisions adopted by the Council.

C) Among the Council's principal functions are:

- ◆ Electing the Director by simple majority.
- ◆ Preparing proposals for amendments to the Center Regulations, which must be approved by a majority of the Council members.
- ◆ Supporting the Director in the implementation of the Center's activities.
- ◆ Providing support to the Administrative Secretariat of the Istituto Universitario Sophia (Article 6 of the Framework Agreement) regarding financial and economic management, as well as the approval of budget forecasts and financial reports, where the Center has financial resources.
- ◆ Deciding on the admission and termination of membership within the Center. Applications for membership shall be approved by a two-thirds majority of Council members. The Council may, by the same majority, declare the termination of membership of inactive members or members whose conduct is inconsistent with the purposes of the Center.
- ◆ Approving proposals for agreements, conventions, and proposals submitted by the Scientific Committee. Agreements with public bodies, private entities, and universities shall be approved by simple majority. Inter-university agreements shall subsequently be submitted to IUS and ASCES UNITA for examination in accordance with their respective internal regulations.
- ◆ Adopting resolutions concerning scientific activities and the establishment of laboratories and research groups.
- ◆ Exercising oversight over the Center's publications and initiatives and ensuring that all activities remain consistent with its objectives.
- ◆ Establishing conditions to promote the mobility of professors, researchers, and students in undergraduate and postgraduate programs through the harmonization and alignment of curricula, thereby facilitating integrated educational pathways.

Article 6 — The Scientific Committee

The Scientific Committee is the academic advisory body responsible for defining the scientific guidelines of the ICTS.

- ◆ a) The Committee is composed of members of the Universities and Institutions participating in the Framework Agreement.

b) Term of Office and Functioning:

- ◆ The Committee may be convened by the Director, who shall serve as its Chair, or upon the request of at least one-third of its members.
- ◆ Notice of meetings shall be given by electronic mail. Meetings may also be conducted remotely through videoconferencing.
- ◆ The Director shall appoint a Secretary responsible for preparing the minutes of the meetings of the Scientific Committee. The minutes shall be archived at the administrative headquarters and distributed to the Coordinators of the Research Units.
- ◆ Resolutions of the Committee shall be approved by a majority of the members present.

c) Among the Committee's principal functions are:

- ◆ Proposing the general scientific guidelines and activities of the Center to the Center Council.
- ◆ Proposing scientific coordination and dissemination initiatives, subject to approval by the Center Council.
- ◆ Providing technical and scientific opinions on projects and research activities upon request of the Center Council.

Article 7 — The Ethics Committee

The Ethics Committee ensures compliance with the principles of integrity, responsibility, and sustainability in the activities of the ICTS.

- ◆ a) The Committee shall be composed of experts selected from among the members of the partner institutions and, where necessary, qualified external experts.

b) The principal functions of the Ethics Committee are:

- ◆ Issuing opinions regarding the feasibility of projects, methodologies, and initiatives in accordance with ethical principles.
- ◆ Upon request, providing information and recommendations aimed at raising awareness among personnel involved in the Center's activities regarding the ethical implications of research, particularly within the social sciences and humanities.
- ◆ Issuing opinions, in accordance with principles of scientific and ethical integrity, concerning research activities in the medical field or related areas.

- ◆ Ensuring the protection of the rights of individuals participating in experimental and clinical studies.
- ◆ Intervening, upon request of the Council and/or the Director, to ensure that studies and activities comply with applicable ethical standards and regulations.

PART III – MEMBERSHIP AND AGREEMENTS

Article 8 — Composition and Membership of the Center

During its founding phase, the ICTS shall consist of the members identified in Article 1 of these Regulations. Each member of the Center shall belong to a Research Unit, namely a working group consisting of at least two members and defined by the Center Council. Additional public or private institutions may join the Center through agreements or conventions to be concluded by the institutions that are parties to the Framework Agreement.

a) Admission of New Members The following individuals may become members of the ICTS:

- ◆ Professors, researchers, and fixed-term researchers of affiliated Universities and Institutions who conduct research in fields relevant to the Center, subject to approval by the Center Council.
- ◆ Faculty members of other Universities, researchers affiliated with public or private cultural institutions, and scholars with recognized expertise, subject to approval by the relevant Research Unit and, in all cases, ratification by the Center Council.
- ◆ b) Admission Procedure
- ◆ Applications for membership shall be submitted to the Center Council using Form A attached to these Regulations.
- ◆ The application shall specify the Research Unit that the applicant intends to join.
- ◆ The list of members of the Research Units shall be periodically updated by the Center Council and made available on the official ICTS website.

Article 9 — Agreements and Conventions

For the purpose of carrying out its activities, the ICTS may propose to the partner institutions (IUS and ASCES UNITA) the conclusion of agreements and conventions with public and private entities, whether national or international, that share the objectives of the Center.

a) Proposing Institutions:

- ◆ Public and private entities, whether national or international, that share the objectives of the Center, as well as interested universities, may submit proposals for agreements and conventions.
- ◆ b) Submission Procedure.

Applicant entities shall submit an application (Form B) containing the following information:

- ◆ the name of the Research Unit to which the agreement refers;
- ◆ the list of members involved (minimum of two);
- ◆ the name of the Unit Coordinator;
- ◆ a proposal for a collaboration agreement (national or international) with one of the ICTS partner universities.
- ◆ c) Activities and Benefits.

Research Units established through agreements or conventions, and subject to authorization by the Center Council, may:

- ◆ Promote and conduct research activities, studies, data collection initiatives, and publications.
- ◆ Propose the creation of laboratories or interdisciplinary research groups.
- ◆ Organize conferences, seminars, summer schools, and educational activities for doctoral candidates and early-career researchers.

Each Unit shall have a Coordinator appointed for a four-year term, renewable once.

The Coordinator may be invited to attend meetings of the Center Council as an observer.

PART IV – OPERATIONAL STRUCTURES

Article 10 — Laboratories and Research Groups

Laboratories and Research Groups are operational instruments established to develop specific research lines and scientific projects, complementing the activities of the Research Units and promoting interdisciplinary collaboration.

a) Definition and Functions:

- ◆ What they are: Laboratories are thematic spaces, either physical or virtual, dedicated to scientific production and the sharing of knowledge on topics consistent with the objectives of the ICTS.
- ◆ Who may establish them: They may be proposed by one or more Research Units or by individual members of the Center.
- ◆ What they do: They carry out research activities, data collection, experimentation, training, and dissemination. Their purposes may be theoretical or educational, experimental or applied, or interdisciplinary in nature, integrating different fields of knowledge.

b) Establishment Procedure:

- ◆ Proposals for the establishment of a Laboratory or Research Group shall be submitted to the Center Council using the appropriate application form (Form C).

Content of the Proposal. The application shall include:

- ◆ I. the name of the relevant Research Unit;
- ◆ II. the list of participating members (minimum of two), including any external collaborators;
- ◆ III. the name of the proposed Laboratory Coordinator;
- ◆ IV. a brief description of the objectives and planned activities;

V. the operational headquarters, where already defined, or a proposal for its subsequent designation, subject to approval by the Center Council.

- ◆ Letters of Participation. The Coordinator shall collect participation letters from the participants (Form D) and submit them to the Center Council together with the proposal.

c) Management of Operational Structures:

- ◆ Coordination: Each Laboratory shall be coordinated by a Coordinator/Director responsible for annual reporting, updating the membership list, and overseeing operational activities.
- ◆ Reporting: The Coordinator shall prepare an annual report including the principal results achieved and any proposals for modification, to be submitted to the Center Council.
- ◆ Duration: Once approved, a Laboratory shall remain active indefinitely unless otherwise decided.
- ◆ Closure: A Laboratory may be closed upon formal request of its Coordinator or by decision of the Center Council if its activities are no longer consistent with the objectives of the ICTS or for other serious reasons.

PART V – FINAL PROVISIONS**Article 11 — Duration of the Regulations**

These Regulations shall remain in force indefinitely and shall continue to apply until amended in accordance with the procedures established herein. Amendments to these Regulations shall be adopted according to the procedures established by the competent governing bodies, in particular by the Center Council.

Article 12 — Publication and Consultation

These Regulations may be made publicly available on the official ICTS website as well as on the websites of the individual partner institutions. Updated versions of the Regulations shall be maintained by the Research Units and made available for consultation by all members of the Center and other interested parties.

